THE ORIGENISTIC CONTROVERSY IN THE HISTORIANS OF THE FOURTH, FIFTH AND SIXTH CENTURIES

The purpose of this communication is to present the views of the Byzantine historians Socrates, Sozomenos and Theodoretus on Origenism and Anti-Origenism, and to evaluate them critically.

Initially, one should remember that all of these three historians continued the *Ecclesiastical History* of Eusebius of Caesarea and were writing during the years of the reign of Theodosius II (408-450).

Socrates (from Constantinople) and Sozomenos (from Palestine) spent their life in Constantinople, where they studied law and worked as lawyers. Theodoretus (from Antioch, Syria, 395?-460?) was ordained (unwillingly) bishop of Cyrrhus in 423, after a long-term *ascesis* and meditation in the monastery of Saint Efpreprios near Antioch, where he was led by his parents at the age of only eight.

Socrates' *History* [1] covers 140 years (305-439) and was completed shortly before 450. It primarily examines church events and occasionally some political happenings. Socrates' convictions are certainly orthodox [2] although he is not always clear and precise in stating the orthodox dogma, « οὐ λίαν ἀκριβής », according to Photius [3]. Being by nature mild and lenient, Socrates tried to avoid religious controversy [4], and disapproved any persecution for religious beliefs. He actually supported religious toleration and freedom, and he even showed love and forgiveness to heretics or schismatics [5]. Hence, Socrates was falsly accused as Arian and Novatian [6].

Socrates' sources are Eusebius, Athanasius, Rufinus, Sabinus [7] and synodal documents as well as pagan writers, a truly rich

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1 PG 67, 33-841.
2 *EH* 2, 1.
3 Photius, *Bibl. cod.* 28.
4 *EH* 7, 19.
5 *EH* 7, 41.
6 Cf. *EH* 2, 1; 5, 20.
7 Cf. *EH* 1, 8; 3, 10.

material, but his ability did not match its huge amount of information, although he was always looking for objectivity and truth.

Sozomenos' *History* was written also before 450 and consists of 9 books including church events from 324 to 439 [8]. This work of Sozomenos is incomplete towards the end. Although Sozomenos completes Socrates' *History* and follows him closely, he disagrees with Socrates in some points In these cases (of disagreement) Socrates must be preferred as more reliable and critical according to Photius [9]. However, Sozomenos knows better the church developments in the West than Socrates.

Theodoretus of Cyrrhus wrote his *History* circa 450 [10] and covers 105 years (323-428). It contains only five books. Although Theodore thus completes Socrates and Sozomenos [11] and had in his disposition greater collection of historical sources and documents, he wrote this work in a hurry and did not use his rich documents thoroughly.

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Now, Socrates considers Origen one of the chief representatives of the Ecclesiastical Tradition [12]. Origen's opponents, according to Socrates, were motivated by partiality, malicious jealousy and prejudice, ἐκ προλήψεως [13]. Furthermore, in evaluating the theological contribution of Saints Basil and Gregory of Nazianzus, Socrates attributes their great influence and importance, to the then universal recognition of Origen's greatness and to his theological writings [14]. Sozomenos seems also to have the same view [15]. Of course, Socrates rejects entirely Origen's « arianizing » (?) concept of « subordination-Christology », which he calls: τὴν ' Ωριγένους σύνεσιν » [16]!

This view of Socrates is in absolute agreement with the statement of Hans von Balthasar that: « Origen is, even in this matter, (of subordination), the most orthodox of the pre-Nicene theologians. He clearly distinguishes the internal divine processions from the creation of the world. The Son is not, as he was for Arius and many before him, a 'means' of creation but the eternal

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[8] PG 67, 844-1630.
[9] Photius, *Bibl. cod.* 30.
[10] PG 82, 881-1280.
[11] According to Photius, *Bibl. cod.* 31.
[12] *EH* book 3, ch. 7: PG 67, 392Aff.
[13] Cf. *EH* book 7, ch. 45: PG 67, 836BC.
[14] *EH* book 4, ch. 26: PG 67, 529Bf.
[15] *EH* book 6, ch. 17: PG 67, 1333CD; 1336AB.
[16] *EH* book 4, ch. 26: PG 67, 529Bf.

birth of love of the Father. Subordination in Origen has a stronger salvation-history aspect and thus can be better brought into harmony with Nicaean theology »[17].

Origen is characterized by Socrates "wise doctor" of the Church σοφὸς διδάσκαλος[18].

Chapter 7 of Book 6 in Socrates' *History* is the most important and most informative report in the schism between Theophilos of Alexandria (385-412) and the desert monks of Egypt. The monks believed that God had a body and human shape: σωματικὸν καὶ ἀνθρωπόμορφον τὸν Θεόν[19] whereas Theophilos argued the contrary claiming Origen as his authority[20]. So Sozomenos thought of the cause of that schism[21] However, when some of those monks went to Alexandria and threatened Theophilos, he gave up his Origenistic view, and in order to pacify and get rid of them he anathematized the person and writings of Origen. Interestingly, Theophilos is presented by both, Socrates as well as by Sozomenos[22], as hot-blooded, partial, and double-faced with special skill to twist doctrines, confuse the tradition, to manipulate people and poison their relations. Using precisely such tactics Theophilos succeeded to divide the monks at Nitria into Origenists (i.e. the followers of Dioscorus and Evagrius Ponticus, who believed that God did not have human shape) and *Anthropomorphists* who were Theophilos' party, according to Socrates[23].

On the other hand, we know that the monks at Nitria were defenders of Origen, whereas Theophilos was anti-Origen through and through[24]. Hence, Theophilos condemned Origen's person and works in a council at Alexandria in 400. Actually, that condemnation was the first synodal condemnation of both the person and works of Origen. In any event, Socrates overlooks this development and attributes the conflict between Theophilos and the monks at Nitria, to Theophilos' malicious jealousy and hostility toward the saintly popularity of the leaders of those monks, Evagrius and Dioscorus. So, Sozomenos also does believe[25].

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[17] H. Urs von Balthasar, *Origen, Spirit and Fire: A Thematic Anthology of His Writings,* Washington, D.C. 1984, p. 14.
[18] *EH* book 5, ch. 22: PG 67, 636BC.
[19] Book 6, chapter 7: PG 67, 684AB.
[20] *Ibid.*
[21] Sozomenos, *EH* book 8, ch. 11: PG 67, 1544CD.
[22] *EH* book 8, ch. 12: PG 67, 1548 C; book 8, ch. 17: *PG* 67, 1560C.
[23] *EH* book 6, ch. 7: PG 67, 688BC.
[24] Cf. Book 6, ch. 17: PG 67, 716BC.
[25] *EH* book 8, ch. 12: PG 67, 1545BC.

Theophilos certainly attacked the followers of Evagrius and Dioscorus and hounded the most eminent of them, four saintly brothers known as the *Tall Brothers,* out of Egypt. When they went to Constantinople in order to appeal for John Chrysostom's support (c. 402), Theophilos became furious and began to work out a plan of John's deposition and banishment. Especially, when Theopilos learned tat the patriarch John Chrysostom (c. 347-407) had received those monks in "eucharistic communion" (rather a rumor according to both, Socrates and Sozomenos)[26] the former asked Epiphanius, the bishop of Constantia (Cyprus), to condemn John Chrysostom, in a council, as origenist. Of course, John Chrysostom was not origenist, and always remained a person of great holiness and of unquestionable integrity. True, he was sympathetic to the *Tall Brothers'* situation, which embroiled him in controversy with Theophilos. But John Chrysostom *was not politician.*

Now, Epiphanius being a piously naive bishop (as Socrates characterizes him) consented to Theophilos' request. John, however, ignored that threat, and continued to favor the monks. Due to Theophilos' manipulations the opponents of John Chrysostom and several officers in the court, who disliked him, succeeded in convening a council (403) in order to condemn John[27]. Chrysostom, who died in exile in 407, was soon revered as a saint, but the controversy which Epiphanius initiated and Theophilos stirred up left a permanent stain on Origen's reputation.

It is clear from the account of Socrates as well, as of Sozomenos that, the accusation against John for Origenism was used by Theophilos first, in order to conceal his own maliciousness and envy against the leaders of the monks at Nitria, and Chrysostom himself. It is noteworthy that even Theodoretus who admired and praised Theophilos of Alexandria as ἀνὴρ πυκνός τε τὰς φρένας καὶ ἀνδρεῖος τὸ φρόνημα, for his heroic courage and success in purging the city of Alexandria from pagan statues and temples[28] attributes, though not explicitly, the opposition of Theophilos to John Chrysostom to the former's envy against the latter[29]. Second, in order to easily persuade the very pious and saintly simple-minded bishop Epiphanius to joint him in his anti-Chrysostom crusade. Actually, Epiphanius even travelled to

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[26] *EH* book 8, ch. 13: PG 67, 1549CDf.
[27] Socrates, book 6, ch. 10: PG 67, 696BC.
[28] Theodoretus, *EH* book 5, ch. 22: PG 82, 1245CDf.
[29] Theodoretus, *EH* book 5, ch. 34: PG 82, 1261CDf.

Constantinople without Chrysostom's previous knowledge, in order to instigate the bishops there and to make them sign an anathematism against the writings of Origen, but not against his own person [30]. Socrates reports how those bishops reacted to Epiphanius. Some of them reluctantly consented to sign the anathematism just because they highly revered the bishop Epiphanius; others, however, refused to sign it for they could not find any anorthodox doctrine in Origen's writings, but only subjective distortions of his mind by his prejudiced opponents [31].

And so the historian Socrates adds his own explanation of this anti-Origenism: those who were not able to reach Origen's self-created greatness and wisdom tried to de-evaluate and maliciously depreciate his importance [32]. In addition, Socrates employs St. Athanasius' testimony that Origen tought the ὁμοουσία (consubstantiality) of Christ (συναίδιον αὐτὸν λέγων τῷ Πατρί) in order to overthrow the argument of Origen's opponents that Athanasius held him as heretic [33].

Clearly, Socrates always insists on Origen's ὀ ρ θ ὴ εὐσέβεια even in his Christology and Trinitarian theology [34]. Hence, he makes Athanasius and John Chrysostom unconditional supporters of Origen's orthodoxy.

Strangely, Theodoretus is silent about the conflict between Theophilos and the monks at Nitria, their relations with John Chrysostom, etc. Moreover, Theodoretus does not mention even the name of Origen in all five books of his *Ecclesiastical History*. But he devotes much space to Chrysostom's persecutions! Of course, Theodoretus is shorter in all his accounts than Socrates and Sozomenos.

In the East, the Origenistic controversy continued at least until the iconoclastic crisis of the eighth century. And even after Origen's condemnation by the fifth Ecumenical Synod (553 at Constantinople II) Origen's theological thought served as background for the integrated Christian philosophy of Maximus the Confessor [35].

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[30] Socrates, *EH* book 6, ch. 12: PG 67, 701ABf. Sozomenos, book 8, ch. 17: PG 67, 1560BC.

[31] *Ibid,* col. 701BC.

[32] *Ibid,* book 6, ch. 13: PG 67, 701CD; cf. ch. 45, 836BC.

[33] *Ibid.* col. 704B. Cf. Athanasius, Περὶ Νικαίας 27, 1-21.

[34] *Ibid,* 704AB; book 7, ch. 6, 749AB; book 7, ch. 32, 812BC.

[35] Cf. C.N. Tsirpanlis, *Aspects of Maximian Theology of Politics, History, and the Kingdom of God,* The Patristic and Byzantine Review I/1 (1982) 1-21.

Origenism became popular and controversial especially in the sixth century Palestine and Syria. The leaders of that controversy were the Origenist monks of the New Lavra monastery in Palestine, who in 514 were the most literate monks and spread their origenistic teachings to all Palestine. The position of the Origenists became solidified after the death of St. Sabas (532), and the departure to Constantinople of their two top representatives: Dometian, Abbot of the monastery of Martyrios, and Theodore Ascidas, head of the New Lavra. Strangely, Emperor Justinian received them (536) favorably, and they were even promoted to the rank of bishops — Dometian as bishop of Ankara and Theodore as bishop of Caesarea in Cappadocia.

The historian Evagrios [36] who wrote a church history, in 6 books, covering the years 431-594 [37], and who is more trustworthy for his impartiality, through use of his sources, and doctrinal precision than all his predecessors (i.e. Socrates, Sozomenos, Theodoretus) [38] gives an account of the Origenistic doctrines of the monks of New Lavra (pre-existence of the soul, reincarnation, and the restoration of all) with special reference to Theodore Ascidas' teaching of *isochristoi* [39]. This last teaching as well as that of reincarnation are not Origen's doctrines. The *isochristoi* believed that in the future life the souls of men would be equal to the soul of Christ. The opposite group, the *protoktistoi,* ecccepted the superiority of Christ's soul, because it was the first creation. Both of these origenistic movements in the first half of the sixth century are strong proofs of the extention of the abuses and distortions of Origen's thought. On the other hand, the anti-Origenists who were mostly uneducated and narrow-minded traditionalists, overstressed some obscure and ambiguous points of Origen's teaching and used (rather misused) them out-of-context in order to magnify his "heresy". Of course, the Origenists in their super-devotion to Origen added some extreme views, which are not found in his writings.

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[36] Evagrios, the historian, was born in 535 in the city of Epiphaneia, in Syria, and was an influential lawyer and political figure in Antioch closely connected with the Patriarch of Antioch Gregory (570-593). He assisted the Patriarch in all legal matters, and even accompanied him to Costantinople in 589, where he succeeded to win over a legal battle for him. Evagrios' work is a most valuable source for the history of the Nestorian and Monophysite controversies during the reign of Emperor Anastasius I.

[37] PG 86, 2416-2885.

[38] Cf. Photius, *Bibl. cod.* 29.

[39] *EH* book 4, ch. 38: PG 86, 2777-2781, esp. col. 2780Af.

All these developments demonstrate that there were not simply certain Origenist and anti-Origenist theologians, but there were created two extensive and radical popular movements of not only a theological mentality, but also of practical, spiritual and administrative complications. Therefore, their struggle was not a struggle between only two groups of theologians, but also between two parties of common believers with different views on true faith and salvation, however. Of course, the monks' interference and fanaticism worsened the situation and intensified the crisis.

It is of special importance that, all contemporary historians, particularly Evagrios [40] do not blame Origen himself, nor his writings, for that massive confusion and crisis of Origenism and anti-Origenism in the fourth, fifth and sixth centuries, but his fanatic and ignorant misinterpreters. Exceptionally instructive is the attitude of John Chrysostom toward the Origenistic controversy, i.e. not to take any side and to remain as neutral as possible. Such an attitude, in my opinion, demonstrates Chrysostom's wisdom and sobriety not to condemn, that is, in the persons of the Origenists Origen himself nor to justify the eccentric anti-Origenists, since the latter also failed to express the mind of the Church, as it was proven in the council of 403, where the anti-Origenists condemned Chrysostom himself.

Now, whether it was imperative or not for the fifth Ecumenical Synod (553) to condemn the person as well of Origen as heretic (and not only his errors), it is important and an extremely difficult question which goes, however, beyond the limits of this paper.

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[40] PG 86, 2781ABf.